

of 99 percent for Down and Edwards syndrome and 92–99 percent for Patau syndrome. Blood is taken after 10 completed weeks from the mother and the results are available within 10 days.

The test can predict the sex and blood type of the baby, and it can also be used to screen twin pregnancies, although not to determine the sex of the babies. The result of this test is either positive, negative, or inconclusive. If the result is inconclusive, it just means there was not enough free fetal DNA, so you will be offered a repeat test.

ACCURACY OF SCREENING TESTS

As more screening tests have become available, the detection rate for Down syndrome, which used to be assessed on maternal age alone, has significantly increased. The aim of screening tests is to provide a high detection rate for Down syndrome and a low “false positive” rate. A false positive means the screening test indicated a high risk of Down syndrome, but subsequent diagnostic tests gave the all clear, which means the mother would exposed to unnecessary testing.

TESTS	TIMING (WEEKS)	DETECTION RATE	FALSE POSITIVE RATE
Combined test	11–14	85%	5%
Integrated test	11–13/15–22	85%	1%
Quadruple test	15–22	76%	5%

Quadruple tests

These screening tests are done in the second trimester, and assess your baby’s risk of Down syndrome from blood tests alone. If after 14 weeks you’d like to have a screening test for Down syndrome, you will be offered the quadruple test, which measures levels of hCG, AFP, estriol, and inhibin A, levels of which are altered in pregnancies with a baby who has Down syndrome. Screening for Edwards and Patau syndrome is done by ultrasound at 20 weeks.

A positive screen

A positive result does not mean your baby has Down syndrome. If your risk is higher than 1 in 150, this is a higher risk result. However, a risk of 1 in 150 means that there is a 149 out of 150 chance that your baby does not have a chromosomal syndrome. Talking to your doctor or a genetic counselor can help to understand your risk and decide whether you want to have a [diagnostic test](#) for a definite result. Factors that might affect your decision could be your anxiety levels, your fears about pregnancy loss, and what you would do if you found out your baby had a chromosomal syndrome. Research suggests that women are more likely to enjoy their pregnancy and come to terms with the diagnosis if they know in advance that their baby has Down syndrome. So diagnostic tests aren’t only about deciding whether or not to continue your pregnancy.

If you have a positive screening test for another more severe chromosomal disorder, such as trisomy 13 or 18, your doctor will talk to you about the outcomes for the baby as